

Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator

Inception Report

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Contact:

Nicoline de Haan (n.dehaan@cgiar.org)

Isidora Markicevic (i.markicevic@cgiar.org)

Vivian Polar (v.polar@cgiar.org)

Marlene Elias (marlene.elias@cgiar.org)

Els Lecoutere (e.lecoutere@cgiar.org)

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Acronyms

AGNES	African Group of Negotiators Experts Support
AGRA	Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa
AoW	Area of Work
AR4D	Agricultural research for development
ASFS	Africa Food Systems Summit
CSOs	Civil society organizations
CWANA	Central and West Asia and North Africa
ESA	East and Southern Africa
FAO	Food and Agriculture Organization of the UN
GEYSI	Gender equality, youth opportunities, and social inclusion
HER+	CGIAR Gender Equality Initiative
HLOs	High-level outputs
IFAD	International Fund for Agricultural Development
IFPRI	International Food Policy Research Institute
IITA	International Institute of Tropical Agriculture
ILRI	International Livestock Research Institute
IRRI	International Rice Research Institute
ISDC	Independent Science for Development Council
IWMI	International Water Management Institute
LAC	Latin America and the Caribbean
MEL	Monitoring, evaluation, and learning
MELIA	Monitoring, evaluation, learning, and impact assessment
NARES	National agricultural research and extension systems
NGOs	Non-governmental organizations
SA	South Asia
SEA	Southeast Asia and the Pacific
SMART	Specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound
TIP	The Indigenous Partnership for Agrobiodiversity and Food Sovereignty
ToC	Theory of change
WCA	West and Central Africa
WEAI	Women's Empowerment Agricultural Index
YPARD	Young Professionals for Agricultural Development

Executive summary

The CGIAR Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator is a strategic initiative aimed at advancing gender equality, youth opportunities, and social inclusion (GEYSI) to make agrifood systems more equitable, sustainable, and resilient, by addressing the structural barriers related to norms, empowerment, resource access, voice, and policies. Building on the legacy and lessons of the CGIAR GENDER Impact Platform and the Gender Equality Initiative (HER+), and based on stakeholders' feedback on the original proposal, the Accelerator confirmed its high-level vision and refined its operational and research strategies during its inception phase (January–June 2025). The Accelerator adopts a three-pronged impact pathway approach:

1. **Co-designing place-based gender and inclusion research** with actors at country and grassroots level, yielding context-specific evidence and innovations.
2. Conducting place-based research in partnership with CGIAR Science Programs to inform and **enhance the equity, uptake, and effectiveness of Science Program and Accelerator innovations.**
3. Delivering evidence and innovations to **influence global discourse, policies, and programs.**

The Accelerator's work is structured across two mutually reinforcing Areas of Work (AoWs): one on Solutions for impact and another on Change through evidence.

A key advancement during the inception phase is the **mainstreaming of youth** as a core dimension of inclusion, through a dedicated sub-AoW: **Youth Thrive**. The Accelerator is developing a **strategic youth research agenda**, emphasizing four priorities on i) generating evidence for rewarding employment; ii) investigating youth and intersectionality in vulnerable contexts; iii) co-creating innovations with youth organizations; and iv) testing and scaling youth-responsive innovations. While CGIAR is still building its global leadership in youth-related agricultural research for development (AR4D), the Accelerator is responding to **strong partner and policy demand** by committing to foundational investments in this area, with plans to grow research, partnerships, and funding to scale impact.

The inception phase also included a thorough stakeholder engagement process, resulting in the refinement of research priorities, strengthened partnerships, and the planning of a biennial global gender conference in October 2025. A theory of change (ToC) aligns 26 high-level outputs (HLOs) with targeted outcomes and long-term impact goals. MELIA (Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment) plans ensure the tracking of progress through specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound (SMART) indicators, outcome studies, and impact assessments.

A comparative advantage analysis reaffirmed CGIAR's leadership in gender and inclusion research due to its methodological expertise, global networks, and track record in embedding GEYSI in agrifood research. Despite limitations in regions like Central and West Asia and North Africa (CWANA) and Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC), strategic decisions were made to maintain engagement where partner demand, research gaps, and potential impact justify action.

A total of \$9 million in pooled funding for 2025 is strategically distributed across AoWs, 12 CGIAR Centers, and cross-cutting functions. Additional Window 3 and bilateral funds (~\$8.8 million) complement this, especially enhancing research on socio-technical innovations and inclusion.

Key risks identified include inadequate funding, insufficient in-house expertise, and limited uptake of evidence. Mitigation strategies include advocacy, strategic partnerships, and improved coordination systems.

In sum, the Accelerator is positioned as a center of excellence and catalyst for change, driving forward the CGIAR's 2025–2030 ambition of building equitable agrifood systems through inclusive and evidence-based innovation.

1. Accelerator overview

1.1 High-level Vision

Building resilient, sustainable, and equitable agrifood systems¹ by 2030, as the CGIAR aspires, requires tackling systemic, multidimensional, and deeply entrenched inequalities. Reversing the ongoing and projected growth in inequality is a prerequisite to achieving thriving agrifood systems for all.

The CGIAR Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator accepts this challenge, and its inception phase reaffirmed the relevance of its **vision**: a world in which gender equality, opportunities for youth, and social inclusion drive transformation toward equitable, sustainable, and resilient agrifood systems. This implies enabling all people—regardless of their social position—to collaboratively design, access, and benefit from agrifood innovations that strengthen resilience, sustainability, and thriving livelihoods. To achieve this vision, the Accelerator will **engage with CGIAR’s entire portfolio and AR4D partners** to develop comprehensive, multi-actor, and multi-sectoral solutions.

During its inception phase, the Accelerator committed to two high-level adjustments: **First**, we will emphasize **social inclusion** as the overarching concept through which to tackle inequities. This social inclusion lens addresses power relations and inequalities among women and men in all their diversity and across groups facing multiple, intersecting forms of marginalization, with an emphasis on youth, Indigenous Peoples, and disadvantaged castes. This lens also broadens the approach from a narrower focus on women’s empowerment, which in and of itself is insufficient for achieving deep, wide, and lasting change. In addition, the evolving political and funding context, with widespread pushback against gender, diversity, and women’s rights, warrants a strategic shift toward research that addresses a broader inequity agenda. Finally, while **youth** research still needs to grow and mature within the CGIAR portfolio, the Accelerator’s inception phase has surfaced lessons from gender research that can be applied to youth, as will be the case in a new sub-AoW on Youth Thrive.

Second, the Accelerator has clearly identified **three impact pathways** through which it will accelerate progress toward CGIAR’s Gender Equality, Youth and Social Inclusion Impact Area:

- 1) Co-designing place-based gender and inclusion research with actors at country and grassroots level, yielding context-specific evidence and innovations.
- 2) Conducting place-based research in partnership with CGIAR Science Programs to inform and enhance the equity, uptake, and effectiveness of Science Program innovations.
- 3) Delivering evidence and innovations to influence global discourse, policy, and programs.

1.2 Achievements from 2022—2024

The Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator builds on the momentum and results achieved by the CGIAR GENDER Impact Platform (2020-2024) and HER+ (2022-2024). It also draws on the multitude of gender, youth, and social inclusion research done by CGIAR Centers.

The Platform and the Initiative built a footprint in 50 countries and established collaborations with many partners within and beyond CGIAR, ranging from national governments, non-governmental

¹ We use the term agrifood systems to refer not only to food, but to all water, food, and land systems.

organizations (NGOs), civil society organizations (CSOs), including women's organizations, universities and research institutions, multilateral organizations, and donors. The Platform additionally consolidated the largest global network of gender in agrifood system researchers. The Accelerator will leverage and grow these relationships, as with the global [gender in agrifood systems conference](#) later this year, to influence uptake of its solutions and evidence. The Platform also developed a wealth of evidence, as well as cutting-edge research methods, tools, and resources. Notably the Accelerator's prioritization of critical research themes is based on an [evidence gap map](#) developed by the Platform. The Accelerator builds on the Platform's efforts to develop guidance materials and offer capacity development to researchers to enhance the quality of gender research. The Accelerator will continue to grow its [Resource Hub](#), developed as the 'go-to' place to access gender in agrifood system resources, such as a database of research methods and a growing series of evidence explainers.

Foundational research on youth, intersectionality, and social inclusion, conducted under the Platform and the Initiative, enabled conceptual and methodological reviews and positions on [youth](#) and [social inclusion](#). In response to trends pointing to the vulnerability of rural youth, particularly [young rural women](#), but also to the potential youth hold as agents of agrifood system transformation, the Accelerator's AoW on Solutions has developed a designated sub-AoW: Youth Thrive.

The HER+ agenda of researching the structural causes of inequality to identify transformative solutions was innovative. This reflects and sets the tone for gender research more generally (beyond CGIAR) that increasingly recognizes the importance of addressing gender norms together with discriminatory institutions and policies to achieve systemic change in gender equality.

1.3 Description of intended research

Value proposition: The Accelerator uniquely bridges the strategic steering of gender equality and inclusion research through close collaboration with technical experts by co-designing relevant, evidence-based, and scalable solutions. Its global reach and established relationships with national agricultural research and extension systems (NARES), policymakers, development actors, NGOs, and CSOs enables it to build more equitable and resilient agrifood systems for women and men smallholder farmers, livestock producers, and fisherfolk. **What sets us apart is our integrated approach:** we generate knowledge and co-create innovations with partners to deliver actionable tools, policy insights, and locally adapted interventions. We drive scientific progress by identifying underexplored but strategic research areas, developing robust metrics and tools, strengthening capacities, and fostering enabling environments for gender and inclusion research in agrifood systems, both across the CGIAR portfolio and within the wider AR4D community. The Accelerator is uniquely positioned to lead this work, leveraging its mandate to accelerate gender and inclusion research, its global network of gender researchers, and its recognized voice in championing gender equality and social inclusion in agrifood systems. The credibility, reputation, and legitimacy of CGIAR's gender researchers is demonstrated by their invited contributions to high-level products, the Status of Women in Agrifood Systems Report (2023), with the Food and Agriculture Organization of the UN (FAO), and their representation in high-level processes, such as the development of the Committee on World Food Security's Voluntary Guidelines on Gender Equality and Women's and Girls' Empowerment in the Context of Food Security and Nutrition, among others.

Intended research across the Accelerator, through its three impact pathways (see Section 1.1), aims to enable CGIAR, and the wider AR4D community, to deliver on their commitments within the CGIAR Gender Equality, Youth and Social Inclusion Impact Area and to accelerate progress

toward the other four Impact Areas. Serving as a think tank and center of excellence, the Accelerator will set the research agenda, deliver solutions, and strengthen capacities on gender equality, youth, and social inclusion (GEYSI).

The Accelerator's work is organized within two complementary and mutually reinforcing AoWs: AoW on Solutions and AoW on Change. Notably, evidence produced by the AoW on Solutions will be integrated into the AoW on Change. Likewise, capacities and innovative methodologies developed under the AoW on Change will inform the research conducted in the AoW on Solutions.

Importantly, research on youth and social inclusion is present in both AoWs. The Accelerator mainstreams a social inclusion approach that positions women, Indigenous Peoples, youth, and other socially excluded groups as central actors across the entire research process. Context will determine the most relevant aspects of social inclusion to examine—for example, in Jordan, research on financial inclusion will consider the needs of refugees, whereas research in India will consider caste-based discrimination as a central axis of exclusion. Research on inclusive governance of land and biodiversity will engage with Indigenous Peoples' associations (e.g., [International Indigenous Forum on Biodiversity](#); The Indigenous Partnership for Agrobiodiversity and Food Sovereignty (TIP)) and organizations specializing in Indigenous Peoples' rights (e.g., Landesa).

The AoW on Solutions: This AoW collaborates with partners to research and identify effective solutions for accelerating change toward gender equality, youth engagement, and social inclusion. It seeks to address the structural barriers related to norms, empowerment, resource access, voice, and policies to identify impactful levers of change. This AoW accelerates progress by uncovering strategies and pathways of change and testing the effectiveness of innovations for achieving gender equality, while advancing multiple goals of food and nutrition security, poverty, climate, biodiversity, and environmental health.

The Solutions AoW tests tailored solutions in specific agrifood system domains, such as agricultural extension, digital climate action, and humanitarian programming, through causal impact assessments, evaluations, and mixed methods research, to improve its capacity to identify best-bet solutions and change processes. For example, this AoW will expand its focus on financial inclusion by testing strategies that offer inclusive access to savings, credit, and crop insurance, including through digital technologies, in South Asia (SA), East and Southern Africa (ESA), and possibly CWANA. It will also assess social protection interventions to inclusively build resilience, including in climate-affected refugee settings. The AoW on Solutions will closely collaborate and co-create research with CGIAR Science Programs and Accelerators (details in Sections 2 and 8), including Food Frontiers and Security, Policy Innovation, and Scaling for Impact. For example, in collaboration with Scaling for Impact, looking at assessments of GESI and youth participation in scaling processes, to identify barriers and opportunities for groups within agrifood systems.

A sub-AoW proposes a strategic youth research agenda focused on engaging young men and young women in agrifood systems. The research will focus on how to provide rewarding and decent jobs and resource access as well as on how to empower them as change agents in climate adaptation and mitigation. These priorities were identified in a rigorous review and discussion paper conducted in partnership with youth researchers at the Institute of Development Studies, University of Sussex. Partnerships with such experts as well as with youth groups (e.g., Young Professionals for Agricultural Development (YPARD), Consortium of African Youth in Agriculture and Climate Change (CAYACC), and the World Food Forum Global Youth Action) will continue to inform the development and delivery of this sub-AoW. While demand, opportunities, and high

prospective impacts exist for this work, achieving these aims is subject to appropriate funding for this new research area.

The AoW on Change: Building on work from the GENDER platform, this AoW focuses on determining what evidence, strategies, and policies can enable structural change to drive integration of GEYSI in AR4D organizations and ecosystem to catalyze equality and inclusion in agrifood systems. The AoW will continue to improve, develop, and test mixed methods and metrics to monitor gender-transformative change and changes in women’s empowerment and associated outcomes (e.g., climate resilience), using quantitative methods, such as the Women’s Empowerment Agricultural Index (WEAI) and qualitative methods such as GENNOVATE, resulting in a rich portfolio of mixed methods ready for uptake by interdisciplinary teams within CGIAR and globally. This AoW will also strengthen the GEYSI evidence base through synthesizing and stimulating research, filling evidence gaps at the frontier of gender and social inclusion in agrifood systems research. For example, it will assess GEYSI evidence needs and priorities for the CWANA region and curate a portal on evidence on climate change, gender, and agriculture. Research in other sub-AoWs integrates youth: For example, the AoW on Change is committed to producing a gender norms measurement tool that integrates an intersectionality framework, with a focus on norms about youth and ethnicity.

The AoW on Change engages with decision-makers (see Section 2) to influence uptake of GEYSI evidence and metrics and inform policy and investment decisions on gender-responsive, transformative, and socially inclusive innovations. As noted above, the AoW also **curates the most up-to-date and comprehensive Resource Hub** on gender in agrifood systems research, offering methodologies and tools for use by these decision-makers and other actors (including NARES, NGOs, CSOs, and CGIAR). The resource base is also a critical resource for gender work in Science Programs and Accelerators.

The AoW on Change reinforces these efforts with capacity sharing to underpin conducive conditions for delivering gender and social inclusion research. Capacity sharing also contributes to integrating GEYSI within agrifood systems research, practice, and MELIA within CGIAR, NARES, and the AR4D ecosystem. For example, the AoW works with regional networks of NARES organized around agrifood system crops or themes (e.g., rice, beans, fish, breeding, plant pathology networks) to strengthen capacity on gender and social inclusion through “learning by doing”, e.g., in joint projects. Finally, the AoW on Change offers capacity support within and beyond CGIAR for the use of gender research methodologies, such as WEAI, which has a dedicated resource center and help desk housed within this AoW.

2. Codesign and partnerships

The Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator's three impact pathways (see Section 1.1) capture the partnerships and approaches to co-designing research and innovations that are at the heart of delivering impactful evidence and solutions. They are also crucial to ensure buy-in from the beginning.

- Under pathway 1, the Accelerator **co-creates the research agenda with national, sub-national, and local partners to address their place-based gender and inclusion priorities in agrifood systems**. This agenda has been shaped over the years by partners such as the Indian Veterinary Research Institute, Rama Krishna Mission Vivekananda Education and Research Institute, India, and the Justice Development and Peace Commission, Nigeria.
- Under pathway 2, **the Science Programs and their constellation of partners are the Accelerator's key partners, as gender and inclusion considerations are integrated into the Science Program agendas**. The initial entry point is the gender section in each Science Program and Accelerator proposal. This is expanding to specific activities with these programs, e.g., we partner with the Scaling for Impact Science Program on socially inclusive demand articulation.
- Under pathway 3, longstanding partnerships, previous collaborative achievements (e.g., the 2023 Status of Women in Agrifood Systems Report, with FAO), and engagement with **global and regional actors, such as FAO, the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), and the Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa (AGRA), will continue shaping scientific priorities** at a global level.

In its original proposal, the Accelerator built on these longstanding partnerships. We will continue to do this as well as evolve. Examples from existing partnerships, which remain central, are as follows:

The AoW on Solutions is built on research and solutions that have been co-designed under the framework of HER+, and in some cases, prior research projects. In India, HER+ conducted participatory co-design processes with local NGOs, CSOs, and NARES that facilitated identifying and implementing contextually fit socio-technical innovation bundles that strengthen the resilience and economic empowerment of women in livestock farming, particularly landless women from Scheduled Castes and tribal communities. This experience now informs the Accelerator's future co-design of innovations with partners. HER+ also co-designed a toolkit for advancing gender equality through sustainability systems and guidance on gender-responsive monitoring and indicators for agrifood stakeholders with the ISEAL Alliance. ISEAL is a global membership organization for Voluntary Sustainability Standards and accreditation bodies and an important scaling partner working with private sector actors in more than 100 countries and diverse value chains. Through this engagement with ISEAL, future research directions with high impact potential have been identified for collaborative research under the Accelerator. Finally, longstanding partnerships with organizations such as Landesa, which champion the land rights of Indigenous Peoples, local communities, and rural women, have helped shape the research agenda on land rights and inclusion in rural resource governance.

For the AoW on Change, partnerships continue to evolve. The growing work on bringing evidence to policy is based on the understanding that having an impact requires the appropriate data but also partners. This work is informed by collaborations with regional agricultural research organizations and networks, such as the Association for Strengthening Agricultural Research in

Eastern and Central Africa, the West and Central African Council for Agricultural Research and Development, the Forum for Agricultural Research in Africa, the Asia-Pacific Association of Agricultural Research Institutions, the African Group of Negotiators Experts Support (AGNES); multilateral organizations such as FAO, the World Bank, Asian Development Bank, African Development Bank; programs such as AGRA.

During the inception phase, the Accelerator’s design has been adjusted based on comments provided by the Independent Science for Development Council (ISDC) and on CGIAR’s forthcoming Partnering Strategy. For instance, the ISDC commentary on co-design highlights that “CGIAR could benefit from more self-reflection and learning from external organizations regarding social inclusion—not only on gender but also concerning Indigenous groups and youth.” In alignment with this observation, the Accelerator, as a first step, is engaging with organizations specializing in youth initiatives, both to learn from their expertise and to contribute to broader discussions on youth inclusion in agrifood systems.

Notably, as part of the **Africa Food Systems Summit (ASFS) 2024** (September 3–6), the Accelerator actively participated in the **Youth in Food Systems Thematic Platform**, collaborating with experts from AGRA, Mastercard Foundation, the African Development Bank’s Enable Youth Program, IFAD, Yara, FAO, USAID, the Southern African Confederation of Agricultural Unions (SACAU), and other key institutions. This engagement helped shape discussions in the ASFS **Youth Dome**, a dedicated space running parallel to the main summit. Additionally, the Accelerator contributed to knowledge-sharing efforts by disseminating its background paper, [Youth in International Agricultural Research for Development](#). Building on this momentum, the Accelerator participated in the 2024 World Food Prize Borlaug Dialogues, co-organizing a side event titled “[A Seed at the Table: Growing Youth Participation in Agrifood Systems Transformation](#)”. This session convened funding agencies and academic partners to identify barriers and opportunities for meaningful youth engagement in agrifood systems, fostering actionable insights. Notably, it confirmed the need to implement a research strategy on youth and to move beyond “doing youth work” to researching and finding solutions for youth, grounded in experiences.

Further, in response to a working draft of the forthcoming **CGIAR Partnering Strategy**—which advocates for “a more systemic and systematic approach to engagement, including a clear value proposition, scope, principles, processes, and robust MEL [monitoring, evaluation, and learning] systems”—the Accelerator conducted a **stakeholder analysis in December 2024**. This exercise identified critical partners for advancing the Accelerator’s objectives, with insights from thought leaders and senior advisors (including those with prior CGIAR experience). The analysis **reaffirmed the importance of engaging traditional actors** (e.g., UN Rome-based agencies (FAO, IFAD), while also expanding into spaces where policymakers, development agencies, NGOs, and international financial institutions converge, such as when addressing issues related to financial inclusion specific to agriculture, where we will continue to build on our collaboration with the [Consultative Group to Assist the Poor](#). The Accelerator continues to be proactive, positioning itself as a key voice guiding research for development on gender in agrifood systems, while fostering debate and collaboration among key stakeholders, and engaging in mutual learning opportunities with partners from the local to the global level.

The Accelerator’s planned **biennial global gender in agrifood systems conference** scheduled for **October 7–9, 2025, in Cape Town, South Africa, points to this convenor role** and to the Accelerator’s facilitation of South-South and South-North knowledge sharing and exchange. The

event is being co-organized with IWMI along with the Ministry of Agriculture, and it will lay a link with the G20 happening in South Africa this year. The event—themed "Accelerating Equality in Food, Land, and Water Systems: Driving Solutions Through Evidence and Learning"—will deliberately incorporate diverse stakeholders to maximize impact and to continue learning about research priorities and research breakthroughs from this diverse network of agrifood system actors.

3. Theory of change and MELIA

3.1 Theory of change

To achieve our vision of a world where gender equality, opportunities for youth, and social inclusion drive transformation toward equitable, sustainable, and resilient agrifood systems, the Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator will work along three impact pathways (see Sections 1.1 and 2).

Following these pathways, four end-of-program outcomes are to be achieved by 2030:

1. Agrifood systems actors use evidence and innovations generated in the Accelerator to address structural barriers to gender equality and social inclusion;
2. AR4D actors, including CGIAR and NARES, disseminate, replicate, and scale gender-responsive, transformative, and socially inclusive innovations;
3. Decision-makers and agrifood system actors use metrics and analytics to understand and monitor progress in addressing structural barriers to gender equality and social inclusion; and ultimately;
4. Women, youth, and socially excluded groups have equitably benefited from innovations designed to enhance sustainability and outcomes from agrifood systems.

These outcomes are interconnected and interdependent, and the achievement of each is not linear. The achievement of the first three outcomes is also a precondition to the achievement of the fourth 2030 outcome. The 2030 outcomes will be achieved through the two interconnected AoWs. Since the original proposal, we have updated the high-level outputs across the two AoWs, to harmonize and clarify what key offerings the Accelerator will produce by the end of 2030.

AoW on Solutions: The Accelerator's first impact pathway will mostly be pursued through this AoW by working with partners on the ground. The AoW on Solutions builds on a [conceptual framework](#) that surfaces four dimensions of inequality and identifies four types of change, from the individual to the systemic level, that need to be pursued concurrently to transform agrifood systems (see details in Section 1.3).

The AoW will deliver two high-level outputs related to measuring gender and intersectionality norms as well as measuring voice and leadership in agrifood systems groups and institutions. It will also deliver 13 high-level outputs related to co-designing, piloting, and assessing the effectiveness and affordability of solutions that address challenges related to the four dimensions of inequality mentioned above.

We envisage that if all HLOs are successfully delivered and the assumptions hold, then five intermediate outcomes will be achieved, reflecting the change in the knowledge, skills, attitude, practice, and policy among stakeholders who participated in the co-design and delivery of the interventions and solutions:

- 1.1. Agrifood systems stakeholders will use the tools, methods, and solutions co-developed with the Accelerator to better pinpoint and **act on restrictive norms** at **different institutional levels** across diverse agrifood systems and contexts;
- 1.2. Agrifood systems stakeholders will use in their own practices the evidence generated in the Accelerator on the importance of **supporting women and youth** and engage in co-developing strategies to empower;
- 1.3. Agrifood systems stakeholders will use the evidence generated in the Accelerator to inform their own strategies to **promote women's access to resources and opportunities** for resilient livelihoods across agrifood systems;

1.4. Agrifood systems stakeholders will use the tools, approaches, and learnings gained through collaboration with the Accelerator to amplify the **voices of women, youth, and socially excluded groups** within agrifood systems policymaking; and

1.5. Agrifood systems stakeholders will use the evidence and approaches developed in CGIAR to design, pilot, and scale up **youth-responsive solutions** to increase **youth involvement** in and benefits derived from agrifood systems.

The Accelerator has adjusted assumptions that are specific to individual HLOs. For example, the investment in interventions that address norms assumes that gender and intersectional norms can change in the short term. It also assumes that normative changes can occur fast enough to keep stakeholders motivated while implementing gender-transformative approaches that bring about gains in productivity, food, nutrition, and economic security. HER+ has yielded [preliminary evidence](#) that these assumptions can hold and thereby provides a basis for continued investment in this area. Furthermore, investments in promoting voice and agency are based on the assumptions that women, youth, and socially excluded groups are interested in and have capacity to participate and influence decision-making processes. For other specific assumptions, please refer to the detailed [theory of change](#) and the results framework (see the results framework attachment). Additionally, all of the overarching assumptions for the AoW on Solutions are addressed through the work of the AoW on Change (see below). the overarching assumptions for the AoW on Solutions are addressed through the work of the AoW on Change (see below).

AoW on Change: The AoW on Change will mainly support and pursue changes along the Accelerator’s second and third impact pathways, to change research practices and influence global processes in agrifood systems. This work is based on the premise that CGIAR’s ability to deliver an inclusive and just food system is limited by significant challenges that require change in agricultural research processes. Agrifood system innovations are often developed with little or no attention to social inequalities, treating women and men as homogeneous groups. Ignoring complex social issues may exacerbate inequalities and prevent some agrifood systems innovations from achieving their full potential of benefits for end users.

As such, the AoW on Change delivers 11 high-level outputs related to developing research methodologies, metrics, and analytics; identifying and filling evidence gaps and synthesizing existing evidence; as well as capacity development of both social and bio-physical researchers to conduct impactful research to promote equitable agrifood outcomes. This AoW also invests in creating spaces and opportunities for researchers to exchange knowledge and learn from each other, and in driving institutional change within and outside of CGIAR to create enabling conditions for inclusive research.

We envisage that if all HLOs are successfully delivered and if the assumptions hold, then three intermediate outcomes will be achieved, reflecting change in the discourse, capacity, attitudes, and practices among researchers and decision-makers within CGIAR and in a broader agrifood systems research ecosystem:

2.1. CGIAR Centers, Science Programs, Accelerators as well as NARES, research organizations, multilateral organizations, think tanks, and possibly NGOs, CSOs, the private sector, and governments will use the methodologies and metrics developed by the Accelerator to **conduct rigorous and ethical research, monitor practices and measure empowerment** and inclusion in their programs and practices;

2.2. Policy makers, governments, multilateral organizations, donors, advocacy groups, NGOs, CSOs, the private sector as well as CGIAR Science Programs and Accelerators will

use the evidence generated by CGIAR and its partners to **inform their decisions, set their priorities and targets, and make investments**; and

2.3. CGIAR and non-CGIAR, NARES, NGOs, CSOs, and private sector actors will **form networks and drive institutional change** toward a truly inclusive environment that prioritizes the right GEYSI research in and outside CGIAR.

All HLOs of both AoWs are based on the assumptions that the longstanding relationships with partners and co-developed research will promote their buy-in; that the research is relevant for the stakeholders' own programs, which will facilitate the uptake of the innovations; that the timelines and political economy will create opportunities for stakeholders to act on increased understanding of the issues; that there will be sufficient funding to generate the evidence and for stakeholders to take action on the evidence; and that the political will and commitment among stakeholders will be sustained to actively partner and invest in co-design processes and solutions. In addition to the pooled funding allocated to the Accelerator, the achievement of the outcomes will be boosted by the CGIAR Centers' projects funded through Window 3 (W3) and bilateral modalities. Namely, intermediate outcomes in sub-AoWs 1.2, 1.3, and to some extent 1.5 and 2.1 will be boosted by at least 20 W3 and bilaterally funded projects.

3.2 Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment (MELIA)

(See the MELIA Plan attachment)

The Accelerator is committed to [results-based management principles](#) to plan, monitor, and evaluate the Accelerator's investments toward its intended results. As outlined in Section 3.1, the theory of change is designed along three impact pathways, within two AoWs. Progress of the 26 HLOs will be tracked and reported annually using the CGIAR Performance and Results Management System tool. The HLOs will be measured with 35 quantitative SMART indicators related to production of innovations and assessments of their effectiveness. The quality of research and relevance of all science outputs will be assessed through a set of qualitative indicators, based on the [science quality tool](#) previously developed by the GENDER Impact Platform. The Accelerator's leadership team will critically reflect on HLO delivery during joint annual reviews and use the learnings to adjust the HLO targets and re-set priorities.

Of the eight intermediate outcomes, seven will be measured with quantitative SMART indicators related to uptake of innovations and evidence by policymakers and practitioners, and one will measure institutional change with qualitative indicators related to adequate funding, formation of networks, and integration of GEYSI in other CGIAR Science Programs. The Accelerator will conduct outcome studies to test the assumptions and assess progress toward the intermediate outcomes every two years, through desk studies of reports and surveys with partners. Learning from the studies will be used to adjust the overall ToC and reassess partnerships and implementation modalities. Additionally, an external mid-term study will be conducted in the third year of implementation. The periodic assessments will provide an opportunity for reflective dialogues to support internalization of gender work and capacity strengthening across CGIAR, as described in previous [GENDER Platform publications](#).

The four end-of-program (2030) outcomes will be measured with four quantitative SMART indicators going beyond the uptake to active promotion and dissemination of solutions co-developed within the Accelerator and driving systemic changes in agrifood systems. Endline studies will be conducted in the last quarter of 2030 through desk studies of reports and surveys with partners. Baseline studies for outcome indicators will be conducted by the end of the first year of the implementation.

In addition to the outcome studies, several impact assessment studies—both causal and non-causal, using quantitative and qualitative methodologies—are planned across the AoW on Solutions, to generate evidence on effective, promising, and cost-efficient strategies to close gender gaps and promote equality in agrifood systems. These studies will provide data for indicators in HLOs 1.1.3, 1.2.2, 1.3.2, 1.3.3, 1.4.3, and 1.5.3.

Many outcome and impact assessment studies cut across areas and research questions, requiring coordination rather than siloed efforts. The Accelerator aims to establish and maintain a MELIA team consisting of a senior scientist for impact assessment, as well as a senior and a junior MEL expert. The MEL experts will work with a community of practice formed by the MEL experts from other CGIAR Science Programs and participating CGIAR Centers to coordinate data collection, including for W3 and bilaterally funded projects mapped to the Accelerator. The senior scientist for impact assessment and the senior MEL expert will play key roles in aligning studies, supporting proposal development, and identifying funding opportunities related to MELIA. The AoW on Solutions will also collaborate with a senior expert funded by the [Dutch Research Council](#), in particular for studies assessing the effectiveness of gender-transformative approaches and socio-technical bundled innovations. CGIAR's Standing Panel on Impact Assessment and other sources are also being explored for this purpose.

4. Comparative advantage analysis (See the Comparative Advantage analysis attachment)

The main comparative advantage of CGIAR's gender work is the institution's long track record of embedding gender and inclusion issues and metrics into its research to address critical agrifood system challenges, for example on crop breeding, livestock systems, climate-smart agriculture, water management, plant health, and agricultural policies. This is reflected within the comparative advantage analysis conducted by the Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator during the inception phase, which shows that the Accelerator is **well positioned** for most of its HLOs for four key reasons:

- i. Unique and longstanding expertise in specific research domains, such as women's empowerment (HLO 2.1.) and gender-transformative interventions (HLO 1.1).
- ii. Distinctive multidisciplinary expertise across gender and social inclusion domains, such as voice and governance (HLOs 1.3.), resource access (HLO 1.4), and technical domains relating to climate-smart agriculture, among others; combined with longstanding regional and country partnerships for co-design, scaling, and strategic policy engagement (HLO 2.2).
- iii. Unparalleled presence on the ground, capacity and expertise for GEYSI research, and on-going co-design and action-research processes with key innovation and implementation partners to identify and deliver relevant gender-responsive socio-technical innovation bundles (HLO 1.2) and gender-transformative interventions (HLO 1.1.2.).
- iv. Deep insights into CGIAR research and institutional processes, a network of CGIAR gender researchers, and the networks within the CGIAR portfolio and external partners needed to engage, understand, develop, and advance agendas (HLO 2); and collaborate with CGIAR Science Programs, Accelerators, and partners to integrate effective evidence-based solutions and approaches for gender equality, youth engagement, climate resilience and nutrition (HLO 2.2) that creates a multiplier effect of the Accelerator's work.

In cases where **other groups or organizations are well positioned to contribute to the Accelerator's intended outcomes, the Accelerator will continue to pursue strategies for partnering, learning, or collaborating** with these groups or organizations with complementary strengths. Such is the case for methodologies for gender-transformative change and norm measurement (e.g., FHI 360, JP-GTA); sharing knowledge and learning resources on norms (e.g., the ALIGN Platform) (HLO 1.1.1); and research on social inclusion related to how climate change challenges place a disproportionate burden on socially excluded people, Indigenous Peoples, and local communities (across several HLOs in the AoW on Solutions). Indigenous research organizations (e.g., TIP) will be key partners to work with Indigenous Peoples on Indigenous land rights, voice in resource governance, and agroecological knowledge systems using methodologies that embrace multiple knowledge systems and their integration. Recognizing that locally embedded CSOs and NGOs are well positioned to implement gender-transformative interventions, since they implement agricultural development interventions at different levels and work with different stakeholders in their region, the Accelerator works with these partners to design and test the gender transformative-interventions (HLO 1.1.2.).

While the demand and need to engage young men and young women in shaping current and future agrifood systems is pressing, the Accelerator acknowledges that CGIAR is not yet a global leader on AR4D on youth engagement in agrifood systems. The Accelerator will continue to develop its established partnerships with experts working with and on rural youth, such as the World Food Forum Global Youth Action, a youth-led movement working to transform agrifood systems;

YPARD, an international movement for young professionals; and with diverse groups of young farmers, agri-entrepreneurs, and agri-influencers.

Combining these partnerships with the Accelerator's wide regional and country partnerships, thematic agrifood expertise, and collaboration with technical experts on climate-smart agriculture, crops, livestock, soil, water and natural resources, agronomy and policies, among others, the Accelerator will be well placed to make critical advancements on youth in agrifood systems. It will build on methodologies and expertise in gender research in these agrifood system domains to identify constraints and pathways for change (HLO 1.5.) and to co-design solutions for youth engagement and co-learn from testing solutions. The Accelerator does not venture into research where CGIAR is weakly positioned.

5. Prioritization (See the Prioritization attachment)

5.1 Knowledge-driven priorities

The Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator has an extensive mandate to work across CGIAR and AR4D to co-design agrifood research and innovations with partners, CGIAR Science Programs, Accelerators, and Centers, and to influence the global agenda. Given the breadth of this mandate, to best target investments, we completed a prioritization exercise during the inception phase to help guide the Accelerator's design and planned work.

The prioritization exercise allowed us to sharpen the Accelerator's HLOs and to more clearly link these with CGIAR's five Impact Areas in target geographies. This exercise worked best for most of the Accelerator's work in the **AoW on Solutions**, as this is where work takes place on the ground, in context-specific settings with partners (see the first impact pathway, described in Section 2). **However, this approach to prioritization did not work as well when assessing work with other CGIAR Science Programs as those workplans are still evolving, and so geographies are not confirmed yet.** This approach was least appropriate for prioritizing our work **on influencing global policies and programs, considering that outcomes under this impact pathway are not as direct or geographically rooted as for the other impact pathways.** In other words, this prioritization exercise was helpful for the context-specific research, but less so for the Accelerator's other work—much of it under the AoW on Change. Below are some highlights from the prioritization exercise.

Geographic Analysis

LAC and Southeast Asia and the Pacific (SEA) are overall regions where less impact is expected across all Impact Areas. West and Central Africa (WCA) and ESA show moderate to high potential in food security, poverty reduction, and social inclusion. SA often exhibits the highest potential, particularly in food security.

Impact Area Analysis

Social inclusion demonstrates the strongest connection to the Accelerator's work, and the highest potential for impact is in this area. This is followed by climate adaptation, to which significant work has been targeted and contributing. Poverty reduction and food security show a moderate link, with potential for impact in some HLOs, while environmental health has the least potential impact. It is important to note that impacts on areas beyond gender equality and social inclusion, such as climate adaptation, poverty reduction, food security, and environmental health, are anticipated to materialize later in the impact pathway, building upon work on social inclusion and gender equality.

HLOs Analysis

AoW on Solutions: HLOs in this AoW show that CWANA consistently has the lowest scores across all Impact Areas, indicating limited potential impact. LAC and SEA also demonstrate low potential, particularly in poverty, food security, and social inclusion, with SEA showing slightly better scores in climate and environment. In contrast, **ESA exhibits the highest potential across the board, particularly in poverty reduction and social inclusion. SA follows closely, showing strong potential in food security, climate, and social inclusion. WCA performs well on social inclusion but has less potential for climate-related impacts.** While LAC shows slightly better performance on climate than CWANA, SEA's potential is modest, with impacts primarily tagged to environmental health and biodiversity. **Overall, ESA and SA stand out with the highest potential scores across Impact Areas.**

AoW on Change: HLOs in this AoW are expected to contribute to **poverty reduction and social inclusion in ESA. SA shows the highest potential across all Impact Areas, particularly in food security, climate, and environment.** SEA has low scores overall, with especially weak scores in poverty, but shows slightly higher scores for environmental impact. LAC demonstrates moderate scores in social inclusion, climate, and environment, while WCA has good scores on poverty, but lower scores on climate and environment. CWANA shows the lowest potential across all Impact Areas.

It is important to note that, given the large number of scores assigned to each HLO (a total of 30—6 per CGIAR region), identifying common trends and setting priorities was challenging. An HLO might score very high in one Impact Area in Region A, but relatively low in another Impact Area in Region B.

5.2 Final decisions on the Accelerator's direction and design

As indicated, for the **AoW on Solutions** and to a lesser extent for the **AoW on Change**, programmatic decisions were made by looking at the prioritization outcomes, partner demand and existing relationships, funder interest, alignment across AoWs, and implementation capacity. In most cases the prioritization data aligned with the mapping above; however, in others, it did not, and decisions then had to be made as to whether to retain the work planned in the Accelerator's original design. So, the final decisions were as follows:

- Under the **AoW on Solutions**, youth, despite rather low impact scores, will be prioritized, especially in response to a clear demand from our partners. The priority will also be to ensure funding for this area of work. We rely on insights provided by the 2023 CGIAR Independent Advisory and Evaluation Service external evaluation of the [CGIAR GENDER Impact Platform](#), which indicated that if the Platform was to expand its mandate to include youth (and social inclusion), it would also need to expand its budget—a lesson that can be directly transferred to the Accelerator. As we are still establishing the foundation for the youth research agenda and solidifying partnerships and networks, we expect that it will take a few years to grow the evidence base and develop and scale solutions to achieve a high impact in this research area. Nonetheless, the Accelerator will pursue efforts in this area considering the demand for, and relevance for CGIAR, of this work.
- For the **AoW on Change** and across the Accelerator, CWANA does not come up as a priority. However, we do plan to initiate some work there, including building up resources on the work done in the region and identifying evidence and research gaps to inform present and future Science Program research. Similarly, although LAC is not the highest priority area for the Solutions AoW, we plan to work in the area in the context of our collaboration with the Science Programs to ensure that the Science Programs working in LAC also integrate gender and inclusion dimensions. For example, the Accelerator will work with the Policies Science Program on making the coffee value chain in Honduras more gender responsive, which has relevance for millions of smallholder producers.
- When looking at the Climate Impact Area, ESA does not come out strongly, but it remains a priority for the Accelerator. This prioritization is based on our climate change-agriculture-gender hotspot mapping and on strong relationships with Kenyan climate negotiators and AGNES, who have requested our support to address gender and inclusion considerations.
- For the **AoW on Change**, although scores are low for HLOs tied to sub-AoW 2.3 (capacity development) in WCA, we are planning to invest in increasing the availability of capacity strengthening resources in the area. This investment responds to partner demand and to a

clear gap in the availability of French-language resources for use in WCA. Translating existing resources into French and strengthening the offer of French-language resources on the Resource Hub will also enable the Accelerator to capitalize on the investments already made in developing these resources in other languages (primarily English).

6. Alignment of W3 and bilaterally funded work

The mandate of the Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator is to work across the entire CGIAR portfolio. The alignment of 21 W3 and bilaterally funded projects fits well within the Accelerator's mandate and provides insight into complementary work conducted by CGIAR. The W3 and bilateral projects will contribute to the achievement of the Accelerator's results. Most projects are mapped to the AoW on Solutions and most strongly complement the Accelerator's work on socio-technical innovation bundles, access to resources, youth, and partly the work on voice and leadership. This is expected, given that W3 and bilateral projects focus on primary research linked to the development and implementation of innovative interventions. These projects provide a pool of interventions that the corresponding HLOs in the AoW on Solutions can draw upon for investigating and learning about possible solutions. In the AoW on Change, the W3 and bilateral projects mostly complement the work on methods and metrics. The HLOs related to evidence synthesis, engagement, capacity strengthening, and institutional change are only tangentially complemented by the W3 and bilateral projects. This is expected due to the nature and scope of these HLOs, which are partly focused on influencing the CGIAR system from within and engaging in global discourse and processes outside of CGIAR. In fact, these HLOs are meant to influence and shape the future W3 and bilaterally funded research in the CGIAR Centers, and therefore the complementarity works in the opposite direction.

7. Plan of Results and Budget (See the 2025 PORB attachment)

Overall, the Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator has allocated funding to 12 Centers across CGIAR. The lead and co-lead roles of the sub-AoWs and AoWs are shared among all Centers. The main implementation approach of the Accelerator is to empower each Center to deliver the right gender, youth, and social inclusion research of high quality. Acknowledging that some Centers already have a bigger capacity for this than others, the Accelerator balances the efficiency and quality of delivery with the capacity development by ensuring that the Centers with less capacity still get funding to enable them to build up. This is a strategic decision that relies on the assumption that without optimal resources, the capacity cannot be enhanced, i.e., the Center and its gender researchers would remain unable to grow.

Among the 12 Centers, IFPRI has received the highest budget allocation for research (23%), followed by IRRI (18%), Alliance Bioversity and CIAT (10%), IITA (6%), ILRI (3%), IWMI and WorldFish (2% each), and others 1% or less. These allocations were partly determined by last year's allocations and continuity of research, adjusted to also meet the above principle on minimum requirement for capacity development and growth. In future years, the Accelerator aims to institute some basic budget principles of fairness, including a maximum percentage allocation to any Center within a sub-AoW. In addition to the research-specific budget, ILRI has also been allocated to budget for the Accelerator's interim Director, program management unit, and the above-mentioned common services as ILRI has hosted these functions for the Accelerator.

Overall, for 2025, the Accelerator has received a budget of US\$8,502,040 from pooled funding. As reflected in this Plan of Results and Budget, 36% is allocated for delivering HLOs in the AoW on Solutions and 29% for delivering HLOs in AoW on Change. The remaining 35% are allocated to cross-cutting functions: 11% for strategic leadership (which from January to June includes an interim Director and Deputy Director, from July to December includes a long-term Director, and across the year includes leads and co-leads of the AoWs and sub-AoWs), 4% for the program management unit, and 20% for common services that include knowledge management, engagement activities, science quality assurance, and impact assessment support. These functions serve both AoWs and also perform some of the Accelerator-level strategic functions that underpin the three impact pathways.

The latest budget cuts were implemented based on the principle that the Centers that had previously (in February 2025) received less than \$100,000 were not further reduced. The Centers that had previously received more than \$100,000 had their budgets adjusted down by 15%. The Accelerator-level cross-cutting budget was cut by 18%. The ratio across the AoWs and crosscutting has to a large extent remained the same.

In 2025, both AoWs will be funded and thus also the HLOs (refer to Section 5 for prioritization decisions). The cuts were mainly for the use-case based prioritization that would have allowed us to work with the Science Programs and Accelerators. The implication of this cut is that there will be limited outputs through this impact pathway. In the **AoW on Solutions**, most investments are geared toward developing and testing measurement tools and in co-designing, piloting, and implementing interventions in the four sub-AoWs. As these sub-AoWs build on the work of HER+, the more mature interventions will begin effectiveness assessments too. The sub-AoW on Youth Thrive is the least developed area and therefore foundational research will start in 2025, building on the [position paper](#) developed in 2024. The work on the co-design of interventions and

subsequent assessment of their effectiveness will be done in future years and will be informed by the foundational research done this year.

In the **AoW on Change**, an investment will be made in the biennial global gender conference that will take place in October in Cape Town, South Africa, in collaboration with IWMI. Another significant investment is made in reassessing evidence needs and action research on evidence uptake, the recommendations from which will inform actions in the future, across the Accelerator, to ensure that all HLOs translate to intermediate and eventually 2030 outcomes. This is also complemented with policy dialogue in the CWANA region and engagement in select regional and global events such as Africa Food System Forum and the International Year of Woman Farmer.

In addition to the pooled funding allocated to the Accelerator, the HLOs are also complemented with the funds from the mapped W3 and bilateral projects (see Section 6) amounting to just under \$8.8 million. HLOs in sub-AoWs 1.2 and 1.3 and to some extent 1.5 and 2.1 will be significantly boosted by these funds. Out of the 21 W3 and bilaterally funded projects mapped to the Accelerator, the PORB includes 16 projects. The information for the remaining 5 projects was not sufficient to include them in the PORB and the TOC of the Accelerator, but this will be completed before the end of September 2025 (these projects are: P-1490-DFAT-Generating Revenues and Opportunities for Women by CIP, P-1529-UNGP-Technical Assistance for Sweet potato processing by CIP, P-1580-IAIO-Market-led Transformation of the Root and Tuber by CIP, Scaling Commercialization of Drought Tolerant Crops (DTC) Technologies to Secure Dignified and Fulfilling Work for 120,000 Youth in Rural Kenya by IRISAT, and W-D-0392-NET: WaPOR Phase 2 by IWMI).

In terms of other Science Programs and Accelerators, this Accelerator will collaborate and co-fund with only one HLO in each of these programs. Most HLOs will be delivered in collaboration with the Scaling for Impact and Policy Innovation Science Programs, followed by Food Frontiers and Security, and Digital Transformation Accelerator (see Section 2 for more details on partnerships).

Lastly, the funding in 2025 will cover work in 24 countries in the AoW on Solutions, as per the first of the three impact pathways (see Section 1.1). In the AoW on Change, the funding is geared toward global and regional work in line with the second and third impact pathways.

8. Cross-Portfolio linkages and geographic coordination

8.1 Cross-portfolio linkages

CGIAR cannot achieve its mandate without leveraging the whole CGIAR portfolio to deliver its Gender Equality, Youth, and Social Inclusion Impact Area. Hence, one of the Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator's three impact pathways (see Section 1.1) works directly with CGIAR Science Programs and Accelerators, as described in Section 7 of the original proposal. This requires developing synergies and forward-looking research agendas with all the Science Programs and Accelerators, and details on specific modalities or themes have emerged during the inception phase.

Cross cutting: Notably, the Accelerator has co-developed a **series of forthcoming briefs** with eight of the Science Programs and Accelerators to shape their gender and inclusion research strategies.

Specific links: An assessment of Science Programs' and Accelerators' intentions to contribute to the Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator reveals stronger matches to multiple HLOs/AoW/research, e.g.:

- Understanding the needs and challenges of youth, women, and socially excluded groups to inform efficient and inclusive innovations, interventions, and capacity building efforts is an objective shared by the Accelerator and the **Policies Science Program**, among others. The Accelerator's work on gender-transformative approaches can provide pathways for successfully achieving this objective.
- Co-designing and testing socio-technical innovation bundles (combining gender-responsive and socially inclusive technologies with the necessary services, products, policies, and delivery models) is an area of work for which the Accelerator will partner with **Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods**, for instance.
- Amplifying the voices of women, youth, and socially excluded groups to co-design programs and policies is an area of work that will occur in partnership with the **Multifunctional Landscapes Science Program**.

Overall, we recommend that Science Programs and Accelerators **develop clear gender and social inclusion strategies** and support their implementation through relevant expertise and adequate funding. These strategies will allow the Accelerator to better support Science Programs and Accelerators by filling evidence gaps, providing adapted methods and tools drawing on the Resource Hub, and contributing to on-demand requests and joint outputs. Capacity strengthening needs should be indicated in these strategies and possibly in the Science Program capacity development plans, and responses to that demand examined and addressed where possible as a collaboration between the Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator and the CapSha Accelerator. Such capacity strengthening will move the system forward in terms of research quality, equity, and [institutional change](#) to create an enabling environment for gender work.

As noted above, funding cuts have impeded the intended collaborative research between the Accelerator and the Science Programs through the use cases, and as such, that work will need to be more fully integrated and carried financially by the Science Programs.

8.2 Geographic coordination

As mentioned under Section 5, geographic coordination works well for the Accelerator's first impact pathway on co-designing research with local partners (see Section 3.1), but does not reflect the work we do with CGIAR Science Programs or on global influence (see Section 5.1).

However, the prioritization analysis did show that the regions of SA, ESA, and WCA consistently show the highest potential impact scores across all CGIAR Impact Areas, representing significant opportunities for the Accelerator. Specifically, SA has the greatest potential for impact on food security, ESA on poverty reduction, WCA and ESA on gender and social inclusion, and SA on both climate adaptation and environmental health.

Some variations exist between the two AoWs: The lower expected impacts in LAC, CWANA, SEA are less pronounced in the AoW on Change, which operates more broadly across regions. The AoW on Change's capacity building and evidence synthesis activities are likely to impact all regions, albeit to varying degrees. Overall, among LAC, CWANA, and SEA, CWANA is projected to have the lowest overall impact, partly because CGIAR and the Accelerator have a smaller footprint in that region than in ESA and SA, for example. The significant potential in SA, WCA, and ESA stems from the Accelerator's established, ongoing, and planned work (i.e., first impact pathway, see Section 3.1).

Moreover, realizing the high potential in these regions is contingent upon strong collaboration with CGIAR Science Programs (i.e., second impact pathway, see Section 3.1), the majority of which show significant presence in these regions.

9. Risk management

Please refer to the following [link](#) with the Accelerator's full risk register. This link is open to ISDC colleagues and others will be granted access, on request.

#	Category	Title	Description	Current Risk Level	Target Risk Level	Actions /Controls to manage risks
1	Funding	Inadequate funding for research on gender, youth and social inclusion in the Accelerator and across CGIAR	Inadequate funding is available for gender, youth and social inclusion, both in the Accelerator and across CGIAR, to deliver results and put into use the evidence generated. Donor interests are shifting, de-emphasizing gender and inclusion.	20	8	(1) Engage with partners in resource mobilization and work across CGIAR, especially with Centers and Science Programs; (2) Generate evidence on the returns to investment in gender research in agriculture and use it to mobilize resources. (3) Use gender and social inclusion strategies to prioritize/strategize research innovation efforts with limited resources (4) Update donor mapping to explore opportunities and strategic alliances
2	Research innovation	CGIAR no longer possesses sufficient gender expertise to be a front-runner on gender research in agricultural research for development	Too few gender researchers in CGIAR Centers and partner institutions hampers CGIAR's and Accelerator's ability to carry out activities and to continue to be the leader in the field. If funding for gender researchers is not allocated across programs or appropriately prioritized, there is a risk that the current limited pool of gender researchers may be further reduced. This would affect CGIAR's ability to maintain its current level of critical leading gender research.	16	8	(1) Advocate with the CGIAR Global Science Team that retaining and hiring gender researchers is high priority. (2) Lobby with donors for more innovative arrangements for utilizing modalities to tap into gender experts external to CGIAR in long term arrangements for internal capacity strengthening. (3) Advocate with the CGIAR Global Science Team that resources are available for professionalization of gender in CGIAR, including for capacity development and for providing supportive environment that will encourage the retention of gender researchers. (4) Tailor capacity development efforts across Science Programs to mainstream gender analysis skills (4) pilot and test gender-transformative approaches to

						capacity development/strengthening
3	Partners and Partners hips	CGIAR duplicates work and loses its central role in gender research for agricultural research for development to other actors	Due to lack of control by the Accelerator over the activities/investments in Centers, there is a risk of duplicating work that other internal and external actors may already be doing - hence affecting the relevance and impacting CGIAR's central role in gender research for AR4D, and thus donor funding.	12	8	(1) Engage with partners inside and outside the CGIAR system and undertake a mapping of main actors involved in gender research in AR4D and analysis of their work; (2) Set up a system that will ensure coordinated and strategic work planning at sub-AoW level, that is coherent and aligns with the Accelerator's HLOs and outcomes, taking into consideration the mapping of other actors and their work
4	Partners and Partners hips	Limited buy-in of evidence and assurance of its uptake by the broader AR4D ecosystem	Due to lack of capacity or political will, there is a risk that the broader AR4D ecosystem, including biophysical researchers within and outside CGIAR, will not be encouraged to value the evidence and outputs delivered by the Accelerator and will not incorporate them into research portfolios and investments to achieve development outcomes.	12	8	(1) Work closely with the partners, Science Programs, Accelerators and Centers, especially in shared geographies, to understand and generate evidence that is demanded; (2) Hold biennial conferences to share evidence and outputs gained through the gender research done in CGIAR and partners (3) Train biophysical and other researchers in how to conduct gender-responsive and inclusive research
5	Research innovation	Poor execution by Centers undermines ability of the Accelerator to deliver results	Working within a diffuse matrix structure where the System or Centers do not prioritize gender, or youth, can lead to poor execution of the work. There is a risk that the Accelerator will not be able to deliver in such a matrix.	12	8	(1) Establish a system that will facilitate planning and tracking of deliverables across Centers. Undertake annual program implementation reviews and use these to inform planning of subsequent years. (2) Prioritize collaborations that do prioritize gender, youth, and inclusion and attention to Indigenous groups

10. Addressing feedback on select topics

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Program/ Accelerator has addressed or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
There is a lack of information on how water systems are covered in the Portfolio.	
There is a lack of information on how climate mitigation is covered in the Portfolio.	
There is a lack of information on how tradeoffs and synergies in mixed systems are covered in the Portfolio.	
There is a lack of information on how environmental health and biodiversity is covered in the Portfolio.	
There is a lack of information on how orphan and opportunity crops and pulses are covered in the Portfolio.	
There is a lack of information on how youth and social inclusion (that does not relate to gender) is covered in the Portfolio.	This is being adjusted in the work going forward. For instance, specific work ongoing in AoW Change identifies methodologies geared to youth research, evidence gaps are also being identified, and the Accelerator is continuing to engage with young farmers and young farmer groups. Starting in 2025, it will be vital to identify more resources to implement a more ambitious agenda on social inclusion and gender. Initial discussions have started with some funders.
There is a lack of information on how capacity sharing (as it relates to internal learning and decolonization of research) is covered in the Portfolio.	

Appendix 1: Addressing specific feedback

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Accelerator has or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
ISDC	
Address the issue of buy-in, both internal and external to CGIAR: in fact, most objectives stated in the proposal require such buy-in to be achievable	The issue of buy-in is explicitly addressed in the updated ToC narrative and the revised underlying assumptions (see section 3.1). The key points are as follows: working with stakeholders on co-design of interventions, accompanied by capacity development efforts, engagements at different levels, providing spaces for exchange, will lead to increased buy-in. The overarching assumption is that if the stakeholders invest their time and efforts in co-design, and particularly if they play a key role in setting the research agenda, the agenda will respond to their needs and they will be interested in what results from it. Having invested time, capacities, and ideas into the work will also incentivize relevant stakeholders to use the metrics, methods, tools to measure progress and benefits and use improved evidence to make decisions.
Have a more credible stance at dealing with GEYSI, clarify how CGIAR wants to work on social inclusion, including which groups will be the focus of social inclusion work. A review of the expertise CGIAR currently has or will need to bring in to do this or partners with institutions that do have the expertise would be important and would improve the credibility of the proposal.	This is addressed in detail in sections 1.1 and 1.3 of this report, as well as elaborated in other sections. The main point is that we will emphasize social inclusion as the overarching concept through which to tackle inequities. This social inclusion lens encompasses gender, youth, and socially excluded groups such as Indigenous Peoples and disadvantaged castes.
Strategize how to balance the portfolio that currently is tilted heavily toward women (although men are occasionally mentioned, but not with much depth nor state-of-the-art thinking).	The Accelerator looks at gender relations of power, which affect different types of women and men. Historically and in the patriarchal societies in which we work, these power relations disadvantage women more than men and there have been under-investments in the needs of women, hence some research and innovations focus on women to redress inequalities. However, the Accelerator addresses structural and systemic change, which necessarily involves both women and men. For example, gender-transformative approaches (sub-AoW 1.1) engage with both women and men to address structural inequities that affect both. With the emphasis on social inclusion, we will be looking at women and men, including from particularly

	socio-economically marginalized groups, such as Indigenous Peoples and disadvantaged castes, and will place a new emphasis on young women and men.
Research questions and methods of working with socially excluded groups , including Indigenous groups, could differ significantly from those used for women and women's empowerment. While the proposal briefly mentions working with youth, a more thorough and honest analysis is required to develop these Areas of Work, including strong partnerships outside of CGIAR.	This is an area of work that is being explored in both AoWs on Solutions and Change, similarly as to with youth. It builds on what lessons from gender can be used for youth and social inclusion, but also what are some specifics for social inclusion. We have added information on some partners and thematic areas of focus relation to Indigenous Peoples and agrifood systems.
Write a better risk management section	CGIAR has developed a risk management platform, and we have worked with the CGIAR risk management expert to revise and update the risks, identify risk levels and targets, and develop risk mitigation strategies for each individual risk.
Review the Theories of Change (overall, Areas of Work and sub-Areas) for consistency and alignment with stated objectives. (more details in Section 3.1 of this report)	We have revised the HLOs at sub-area of work level, to harmonize the approach, remove duplications, and prioritize. There are now 26 HLOs. – We have harmonized the intermediate outcomes across sub-AoWs, AoWs, and Accelerator level. There are now five intermediate outcomes for AoW on Solutions and three for AoW on Change. – We have moved one outcome from the intermediate level to the end-of-program level and there are now four 2030 outcomes. – We have updated the indicators and targets for HLOs and outcomes, ensuring it is clear what the Accelerator will deliver, what changes it aims to influence, and how those would be measured. – We have revised and clearly defined assumptions that underpin each individual HLO and outcome, as well as explaining the connections between the HLOs and outcomes.
Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation	
High-level vision lacks any data points. The FAO data on women's increase in hunger (vis-a-vis men's) would seem to fit well with the "challenges and megatrends" for example. More recent FAO data points on gender issues in climate change might help set the table for	Data points have been added in the final version of the proposal.

GEYSI's role vis-a-vis the CGIAR's mandate for climate adaptive agriculture.	
Emerging Areas of Work. This section is disappointing. It is generic to good gender research rather than specific to gender research in agrifood systems. Most importantly it does not include any reflection of what was learned from the earlier work of the GENDER Platform and HER+ these past few years to help guide what has emerged as priorities for the future, nor does it build out from the lessons and recommendations from the 2023 Independent Evaluation of the GENDER Platform.	This is now addressed in detail in Section 1 of this report.
Use-Case-based prioritization. What are the top questions that must be answered? Could these use cases be tied to specific global evidence gaps as revealed in the Gender in Agriculture Evidence Gap Map or the Gender-Climate Hotspots Mapping or to specific burning questions that would tie together the work of the Climate and Nutrition mega-programs with an inclusion lens, to name a few examples. Bottom line: based on its tracking of the field globally, the GEYSI Accelerator needs to lead the prioritization of use cases, and not only respond to widespread and disparate demand. It would be great to see what use cases the GEYSI team recommends as top priority, and why.	The use-case-based prioritization has been put on hold, as the funding set aside for this was part of the cuts. It is envisioned that the interactions and lessons this year in working with the Science Programs and Accelerators will allow us to still use the use-case approach in 2026 to 20230.
Comparative advantage. Comparative Advantage and Theories of Change. A distinct comparative advantage of CGIAR's gender research is that you have a track record of embedding gender and inclusion issues and metrics into crop breeding, livestock health care systems, soil, water and tree management, agriculture policies, and the like. No other organization can deliver on gender research for climate adaptive agriculture like the CGIAR can. And yet, such topics are absent from the sections on Comparative Advantage and related theories of change. How many gender researchers does the CGIAR have now? Top innovations?	This is now addressed in detail in Section 4 of this report.
Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office	

Further clarity on the key research questions on youth and inclusion would be helpful – and, in particular, how this complements research on youth and inclusion in other programmes such as Policy Innovation.	This is covered in the inception report. Specifically with the Policy Science Program, the Accelerator has been working closely and engaged with KIPPRA (Kenya Public Policy Research and Analysis) in their annual conference, which this year was on youth.
How will the accelerator be operationalized?	The Accelerator will be operationalized through the three impact pathways and through working with the CGIAR Science programs. It is also part of the Global Science Team. Details on this are elaborated in Sections 1 and 2 of this report.
How will leadership in the programme drive OneCG results on gender equality, youth and social inclusion?	With the arrival of the Chief Scientist, and the creation of the Global Science Team, there is a multitude of opportunities to ensure institutional change, work closer with Science Programs (once the directors have been appointed) and work with the Global Science Team. As the 2030 strategy upholds the importance to deliver on the Impact Areas, and as one is on gender equality, youth and social inclusion, this will mean continued engagement and support by management.